

Psalms 96

Sing Unto the Lord a New Song

O sing unto the Lord a new song: sing unto the Lord, all the earth

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O sing unto the LORD a new song: sing unto the LORD, all the earth.
- 2 Sing unto the LORD, bless his name; shew forth his salvation from day to day.
- 3 Declare his glory among the heathen, his wonders among all people.
- 4 For the LORD is great, and greatly to be praised: he is to be feared above all gods.
- 5 For all the gods of the nations are idols: but the LORD made the heavens.
- 6 Honour and majesty are before him: strength and beauty are in his sanctuary.
- 7 Give unto the LORD, O ye kindreds of the people, give unto the LORD glory and strength.
- 8 Give unto the LORD the glory due unto his name: bring an offering, and come into his courts.
- 9 O worship the LORD in the beauty of holiness: fear before him, all the earth.
- 10 Say among the heathen that the LORD reigneth: the world also shall be established that it shall not be moved: he shall judge the people righteously.
- 11 Let the heavens rejoice, and let the earth be glad; let the sea roar, and the fulness thereof.
- 12 Let the field be joyful, and all that is therein: then shall all the trees of the wood rejoice
- 13 Before the LORD: for he cometh, for he cometh to judge the earth: he shall judge the world with righteousness, and the people with his truth.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 96 widens its summons to worship far beyond Israel, calling all the earth and all the nations to recognize the Lord's greatness and coming judgment. Its 'new song' language signals fresh cause for praise—likely tied to a specific act of salvation—while its vision of creation itself rejoicing anticipates final, universal justice. Henry reads it as a missionary psalm before missions had a name, insisting that God's glory is not a private possession of Israel but a message meant for every nation.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The call to sing a new song is addressed to all the earth, not merely to Israel: bless His name, show forth His salvation daily, declare His glory among the heathen and His wonders among all people. Worship is framed from the outset as a message meant to travel outward.

Verse 4-6

The reason for this universal summons is comparative: the Lord is great and greatly to be praised, to be feared above all gods, since the gods of the nations are mere idols while the Lord made the heavens. Honour, majesty, strength, and beauty are said to be found specifically in His sanctuary—true glory has an actual source, not a scattered guess.

Verse 7-9

The nations themselves are addressed directly: give unto the Lord glory and strength, bring an offering, worship Him in the beauty of holiness, and let all the earth tremble before Him. Worship here is not passive spectating but active, costly response.

Verse 10-13

The psalm climaxes in a declaration to be spoken among the heathen: the Lord reigns, the world is established and will not be moved, and He will judge the people righteously. Creation itself is summoned to rejoice—heavens, earth, sea, fields, and every tree of the wood—because the Lord comes to judge the earth with righteousness and truth. Judgment, remarkably, is presented as good news worth creation's own celebration.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Praise for God's greatness is never meant to remain a private or national possession; it is a message with an intended global audience, urging every nation and even creation itself to recognize the Lord's reign. Far from being a grim threat, God's coming

judgment is pictured as cause for the whole created order to rejoice, since righteous judgment is what finally sets everything right.

Application for life today.

Consider your own worship as having an intended audience beyond yourself—what would it mean to actively 'declare his glory among the heathen' (v. 3) rather than keep praise privately contained? When God's judgment feels like an uncomfortable topic, let this psalm's vision reframe it: righteous judgment is good news that even trees and seas are pictured celebrating (vv. 11–12). Bring an actual offering, not just words, in response to God's worth, as verse 8 calls for.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Who in your life or sphere of influence needs to hear you 'declare his glory' (v. 3) rather than keep your faith privately contained?

2. How does picturing creation itself rejoicing over God's coming judgment (vv. 11–13) change your own feelings about that judgment?

3. What would bringing an actual, costly 'offering' in worship (v. 8) look like for you this week, beyond words alone?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).